



School of AI & Data for Business & Society
Paris Region · Nice Côte d'Azur

Final Year Project (PFE) Writing Guidelines

Grande Ecole Programme PGE5 – AI & Data Science

– Academic Year 2025–2026

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1 Overview of the Final Year Project

1.1 Definition and Objectives

The Final Year Project (*Projet de Fin d'Études*, PFE) is the capstone of the aivancity PGE5 programme. It consists of a minimum 6-month industry internship, culminating in the submission of an academic report and an oral defence before a mixed academic–industry jury.

The PFE is designed to demonstrate the student's ability to:

- Identify and formalise an AI or data science problem in a professional context;
- Conduct a rigorous, positioned literature review;
- Design, implement and evaluate a technical solution;
- Communicate complex results effectively to both academic and professional audiences.

1.2 Assessment Criteria

Criterion	Report (%)	Defence (%)
Scientific and technical quality	35	30
Methodological rigour and reproducibility	25	20
Critical analysis and positioning	20	20
Writing / presentation quality	15	20
Compliance with standards and deadlines	5	10
Total	100	100

2 Format Requirements

2.1 General Rules

Parameter	Requirement
Paper format	A4
Length	60–90 pages (excluding appendices, bibliography, and front matter)
Font	Calibri 12pt (Word) / Latin Modern or Computer Modern 12pt (L ^A T _E X)
Line spacing	1.5
Margins	2.5 cm (top/bottom), 3 cm (inner/binding), 2.5 cm (outer)
Language	English (both a French <i>résumé</i> and an English abstract are required)
Page numbers	Roman numerals for front matter; Arabic numerals for the body
Submission format	PDF/A (archival) + .docx or .tex sources

2.2 Mandatory Structure

The structure below is mandatory. The order of chapters may be adjusted with the agreement of the academic supervisor.

1. **Cover page** (use the provided template)
2. **Acknowledgements** (max. 1 page)
3. **Abstract** in English + *Résumé* in French (250–300 words each, with keywords)
4. **Table of Contents**
5. **List of Figures** (if ≥ 3 figures)
6. **List of Tables** (if ≥ 3 tables)
7. **List of Abbreviations and Acronyms**
8. **Introduction** (3–5 pp.)
9. **State of the Art** (10–15 pp.)
10. **Project Context and Scope** (5–8 pp.)
11. **Methodology and Technical Approach** (15–20 pp.)
12. **Results and Analysis** (10–15 pp.)
13. **Conclusion and Future Work** (3–5 pp.)
14. **Bibliography** (min. 20 references)
15. **Appendices** (labelled A, B, C...)

3 Section-by-Section Writing Guide

3.1 Cover Page

Mandatory elements:

- aivancity logo (provided – do not modify or rescale disproportionately);
- Label “Grande Ecole Programme PGE5 – AI & Data Science”;
- Project title and subtitle;
- Student name, industry supervisor, academic supervisor, host company;
- Academic year and defence date.

3.2 Abstract

- Recommended structure: context → problem → method → results → conclusion;
- At least 5 keywords, chosen to maximise indexability in bibliographic databases;
- The abstract must stand alone – no references, no unexplained acronyms.

3.3 Introduction

Follow the funnel structure – from the general to the specific:

1. Macro context (industry sector, societal stakes of AI);
2. Micro context (company, department, project motivation);
3. Clear, precise problem statement;
4. SMART objectives and your specific contributions;
5. Chapter-by-chapter roadmap (one sentence per chapter).

3.4 State of the Art

- Do **not** summarise papers one by one – organise by themes or research strands;
- Prioritise recent sources (≤ 5 years) alongside foundational/seminal works;
- Close with a comparative table of approaches and an explicit positioning of your work;
- Minimum: 15 peer-reviewed academic references (journals or A/A* conferences).

Recommended venues: NeurIPS, ICML, ICLR, ACL, EMNLP, CVPR, ECCV, KDD, SIGKDD, IEEE TNNLS, JMLR, and arXiv (cs.LG, cs.AI, stat.ML) for preprints.

3.5 Project Context and Scope

- Describe the company factually – this is not a promotional section;
- Clearly state your actual role, the data you accessed, and the constraints you operated under;
- Specify the legal framework (GDPR, confidentiality agreements, data anonymisation).

3.6 Methodology

This is the most important section of the report. It must be **reproducible**:

- Justify every technical choice (why this model? this architecture? this split?);
- Include mathematical formulations for loss functions, metrics, and key operations;
- Report all hyperparameters and the validation strategy (cross-validation, early stopping, etc.);
- For code: include commented excerpts in the body; provide the full codebase via a Git link.

3.7 Results and Analysis

- Always compare against at least one meaningful baseline;
- Report confidence intervals or statistical significance tests when variance is non-negligible;
- Conduct error analysis: what does the model get wrong and why?
- Discuss generalisation: distribution shift, out-of-distribution behaviour, known failure modes.

3.8 Conclusion

- Directly answer the research question posed in the introduction;
- Do not introduce new results or findings in the conclusion;
- Propose concrete, realistic future directions and next steps if the project continues.

4 Typographic and Formatting Standards

4.1 Headings and Numbering

- Chapters: Arabic numerals (1, 2, ...);
- Sections: decimal numbering (1.1, 1.2, ...);
- Subsections: 1.1.1, 1.1.2, ... (maximum 3 levels of heading);
- No full stop at the end of a heading;
- Each chapter starts on a new page.

4.2 Body Text

- Full justification;
- Paragraphs separated by a blank line *or* a first-line indent – not both;
- Avoid sentences exceeding 40 words;

- Write in the present or past simple tense; avoid the first-person singular (“I”) – use “we”, “this work”, or passive constructions instead.

4.3 Figures

1. Every figure must be **referenced in the text** before it appears;
2. Numbering: “Figure X.Y” (X = chapter, Y = figure number within the chapter);
3. Caption: placed **below** the figure, descriptive, self-contained – always cite the source if not original;
4. Resolution: minimum 150 dpi for plots; 300 dpi for photographs;
5. Preferred formats: PDF or SVG (vector) for diagrams; PNG for screenshots;
6. Minimum font size inside figures: 9 pt;
7. Colours: use a colour-blind-friendly palette (avoid red/green as the sole differentiator).

Example of a correct caption:

Figure 4.2 – Transformer architecture used for text classification. Arrows indicate information flow. $d_{model} = 512$, $h = 8$ attention heads. Source: author, adapted from Vaswani et al. (2017).

4.4 Tables

1. Numbering: “Table X.Y” – caption placed **above** the table;
2. Use `booktabs` (L^AT_EX) or the academic table style (Word) – no vertical borders;
3. Always specify units in column headers;
4. Never leave a table without commentary in the body text.

4.5 Mathematical Equations

- Number all significant equations: (1), (2), ...;
- Define every variable and symbol on first use;
- Reference each equation in the surrounding text;
- Use standard notation for the field; use `amsmath` in L^AT_EX.

4.6 Source Code

- Use a monospace font (Courier, Consolas, JetBrains Mono);
- Number lines;
- Limit in-body excerpts to 30–40 lines; annotate and break up longer blocks;
- Caption: “Listing X.Y – Description” placed below the block;
- Full code belongs in an appendix or a linked Git repository.

5 Bibliography

5.1 IEEE Style (Recommended)

IEEE citation style is recommended for AI and data science work.

5.1.1 In-text citations

- Numeric citations in square brackets: [1], [2, 3], [4]–[7];
- References are numbered in order of first appearance in the text;
- Example: “The attention mechanism was introduced by Vaswani et al. [1].”

5.1.2 Reference entry formats

- **Journal article:** I. Last, “Article title,” *Journal Name*, vol. X, no. Y, pp. xx–xx, Month Year.
- **Conference paper:** I. Last, “Paper title,” in *Proc. Conference Name*, City, Country, Year, pp. xx–xx.
- **Book:** I. Last, *Book Title*, ed. City: Publisher, Year.
- **Website:** Author/Org., “Page title,” [Online]. Available: URL. [Accessed: DD Mon. YYYY].

5.2 APA 7th Edition (Alternative)

- Author–date citations in text: (Vaswani et al., 2017);
- Reference list sorted alphabetically by first author’s surname;
- Always include DOI when available.

5.3 Quantitative Requirements

Source type	Minimum
Peer-reviewed journal articles	8
Conference papers (A* / A / B rank)	6
Academic books or book chapters	2
Other (reports, websites, datasets, technical documentation)	4
Total minimum	20

Important: Wikipedia, personal blogs and library documentation pages do not count as academic references. They may be cited as footnotes only.

5.4 Reference Management Tools

- **Zotero** (free, open-source, browser extension, automatic BibTeX export);
- **Mendeley** (free, Word integration);
- **JabRef** (advanced BibTeX interface, recommended for L^AT_EX);
- **Connected Papers** for identifying related work in a field.

6 Ethics, Confidentiality and Data Protection

- If personal data are used, specify the legal framework (GDPR, company DPA, CNIL declaration);
- Obtain written authorisation from the company before disseminating or publishing the report;
- Sensitive or proprietary data must be anonymised or replaced with synthetic data in the report;
- Explicitly declare any use of generative AI models (LLMs, diffusion) during the writing process;
- Disclose any conflicts of interest.

Mandatory notice for confidential reports: Add **CONFIDENTIAL – Do not distribute** to the header/footer and cover page. Specify the confidentiality period (e.g. 2 years). A non-confidential version must be provided to the jury.

7 Use of Generative AI

The use of generative AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, GitHub Copilot, etc.) is permitted within the PFE framework, subject to the following rules:

1. **Mandatory declaration:** Any use of generative AI must be declared in a dedicated appendix, specifying the tools used, the tasks for which they were employed, and the extent of their use.
2. **Intellectual content:** Analyses, interpretations, methodological choices and conclusions must reflect your own reasoning. AI tools may not substitute for expert judgement.

3. **Verification:** Any AI-generated content must be verified against primary sources. You are fully responsible for the accuracy of all information in the report.
4. **Code:** AI-assisted code (Copilot, Cursor, etc.) must be fully understood, commented, and mastered by the student.
5. **Plagiarism:** The report will be subjected to plagiarism detection. A report written predominantly by AI will be failed.

8 Timeline and Submission Procedure

Milestone	Required action
M+1 (PFE start)	Phase 1 report created, Topic validated by academic supervisor
M+2	Progress check: introduction + state of the art (draft)
M+4	Progress check: methodology + preliminary results
July end	Full draft submitted to academic supervisor for feedback
31 August 2026	Final submission on the aivancity platform (PDF + sources)
Defense day)	Oral presentation (20 min) + jury Q&A (20 min)

8.1 Submission Format

- **Report:** one PDF/A file named PFE_PGE5_LAST_First_YYYY.pdf;
- **Sources:** a .zip archive containing Word/.tex source files and all figures;
- **Code:** link to a Git repository (GitHub, GitLab) with a README;
- **Slides:** .pdf or .pptx defence presentation file.

9 Final Submission Checklist

Review every item before submitting:

- Cover page complete with aivancity logo;
- Abstract in English + résumé in French (250–300 words, keywords);
- Table of contents, list of figures, and list of tables are up to date;
- All figures and tables are numbered and captioned;
- All figures and tables are referenced in the text before they appear;
- All equations are numbered and all symbols defined;
- Minimum 20 bibliographic references (at least 14 academic);
- Citation style is consistent throughout (IEEE or APA, not mixed);

Spell-checked and grammar-checked (native speaker or professional proofreading recommended);

Page numbers are correct (Roman/Arabic transition at main matter);

Headers and footers are present on all pages;

Report is between 60 and 90 pages (excluding front matter, bibliography, appendices);

Generative AI declaration included (if applicable);

Company dissemination authorisation attached;

PDF/A file generated and verified (no missing fonts, no broken links).